Capitalism, Advertising and Mad Men

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This essay talks about advertising, in particular, the kind characterised by Madison Avenue and its role in the upkeep of capitalism. Alongside the discussions we refer and make comparisons to the show *Mad Men (2007)*[1], and the multiple instances when it lays bare the workings of the Madison Avenue firms and their role in the capitalist economy and society at large.

Introduction

Classical Marxist theory stipulates the existence of a surplus value of labour appropriated by capitalists. One particular exercise of this surplus value is in the *expenses of circulation*. They are costs expended in attempt at realisation of this surplus value itself. Marx argued that these expenses of circulation add no value to the commodity itself but are only changes in its form. [Mar92]

The tendency of capitalist markets towards monopolies, or an oligopolic competition of a very few large firms necessitate the existence of advertising. It becomes necessary for firms to conjure superficial differences between their mostly similar products to ensure survival and market dominance. This leads to distinction among commodities which might functionally be the same, but in the mind of the consumers different brands elicit different emotional responses. Certain products are associated with more nostalgia or become signifiers of larger cultural capital than certain other products in the same commodity category.

In such an economy with little distinction between products in the market and fierce competition, the only respite to capitalist firms is advertising. As Paul A. Baran and Paul M. Sweeny put it in their work *Monopoly Capital*— "...advertising becomes to an ever increasing extent the principal weapon of the competitive struggle." [Bar66] The authors argue that in a market with multiple smaller producers comprising of only tiny slices of the market, with more or less homogeneous products, there is very little scope for advertisement. These firms can only sell at the going market price, for even a little increment in the price of an individual firm's products in unlikely to prompt a similar reaction from the multitude of other firms. If every other firm continues to sell at the unchanged price, it is likely that the firm that increased the price runs out of business. In such a scenario the scope for advertisement is very small and even advertisement by producers' associations trying to increase the overall demand for the entire product category have been unsuccessful in the history of advertising.

However in conditions where there are only a handful of very large players with large market shares, the firms have much larger pull in dictating the output of the market itself and also have larger ability to distinguish themselves from their competitors, even if this distinction, in reality, is superficial. An understanding of this is reflected in the show *Mad Men* when Don Draper in a marketing meeting with a cigarette company talking of their advertising prospects says, "This is the greatest advertising opportunity since the invention of cereal. We have six identical companies making six identical products." . This distinction between the products is created by aggressive marketing and advertising campaigns, by distinct brand names, trademarks, packaging and product variations. These large companies are often able to create a market sentiment where their products and the products of their competitors are no longer close substitutes. With increase in advertising and public attachment to a particular brand, the demand for their product

[1] set in the 1960s, centered around people in the advertising industry who work in Madison Avenue. Don Draper, a protagonist in the show, is the creative director of a mid-sized advertising agency.

becomes more inelastic and the dominance of the propagator of the brand is further deepened in the market. [Bar66]

We see that in such a market, it is also possible for the capitalist firms to price gouge in a way that markets broken up into smaller producers do not have the capacity to, from [GS17]:

> In 2015, Turing Pharmaceuticals prompted widespread public outrage by abruptly raising the price of the anti-parasitic drug Daraprim from $13.50 to $750 per pill. In the same year, Valeant Pharmaceuticals increased prices sixty-six percent across its entire brand-name drug line, far outpacing the price-raising strategies of its rivals. The brazen nature of this latest round of prescription drug price gouging has opened Big Pharma to populist critiques from both the Left (which decries the mega-profits taken at the expense of human health) and the Right (represented in President Donald Trump, who was confounded by the fact that the United States [US] government does not aggressively negotiate drug prices). The Pharmaceutical Research and Manufacturers of America (PhRMA), a leading industry trade group, responded by launching a new advertising campaign— "#GOBOLDLY"—aimed at persuading older middle-class Americans to accept rising drug prices in exchange for cutting-edge biomedical breakthroughs.

Big Pharma in the USA invests significant amounts on marketing with some of the largest chunks going to direct-to-consumer and direct-to-physician marketing[1]. These marketing tactics often include gifts to physicians, of a variety of consumer goods. Often a single pharma company owns multiple competing brands of the same drug which go further to reveal the monopolistic nature of this industry which seem to only further the scope for advertisement.

New and Happy

Advertisement's purpose has often been to drive desire where none would otherwise exist. It forces us to correlate the shiniest new things with happiness, to own the newest products is to treat yourself, it is to give yourself what you want. The way American holidays are celebrated has long been fully commercialised. Schmidt claims that this process of commercialisation and reshaping of the American holidays advanced in the latter half of the 19th century after the Civil War. He further adds—"The expanding consumer culture-with its emphasis on advertising, display, fashion, desire, abundance, emulative buying, and self-realization-gave the holidays new drama and color. Civic, religious, and folk liturgies now intermingled with commercially constructed and manipulated holiday rituals centered on mass consumption." [Sch91] The association of consumption with celebration and happiness has been a long drawn process and something deeply ingrained in the history of advertising. The classical American Dream and its fascinations in popular media of the happy life of a man and his family correlated with the imagery of the fordist worker with suburban housing and a car, having 'made it' in the land of the free, is now enjoying it in the way of American consumerism. In Mad Men, we see Don connecting happiness to a billboard, "...you know what happiness is? It's the smell of a new car. It's freedom from fear. It's a billboard on the side of the road that screams that whatever you're doing is okay."

[1] https://www.pewtrusts.org/en/research-and-analysis/fact-sheets/2013/11/11/persuading-the-prescribers-pharmaceutical-industry-marketing-and-its-influence-on-physicians-and-patients

The need for advertising to market newness exists only in the marketing sphere and does not reach back into the actual production. It is not new production that is driving advertisements for new products but newness is being invented out of thin air. This is markedly seen in the advertising campaign by Claude Hopkins (a famed copy writer) for a brewery which has the tag, "OUR BOTTLES ARE WASHED WITH LIVE STEAM!" and the cigarette marketing campaign of George Washington Hill, "IT'S TOASTED!" The latter of which is also featued in Mad Men. Both of these campaigns are claiming things which are an industry standard but notwithstanding, these advertising campaigns make them new features of the regular old product. [Bar66]

However, from the middle of the 20th century, the rising prominence of advertising has led to advertising being driven from production within companies to driving production itself. The sales teams with their advisors from advertising firms dictated what the factories were to produce. Often this was just marginally different products that were different in design but functionally the same. This posits that firms keep continually producing new products, and as one would expect, this results in a flurry of products with frivolous changes. Every year we get the new version of cars and mobile phones, all only marginally different from the other. Electronic device manufacturers have in particular adopted this to mean low serviceability and life of their products. Apple's iPhones are notorious for their low repairability, almost as if it is a planned event that the phone you buy today is meant to be binned in a year or two as it inevitably fails in some way or the other. Planned Obsolescence has now become a practice that is widely known to prevail in capitalist production and manufacturing and its inextricable ties to advertisement and the constant promise of 'something new' have also contributed to increase in the amount of e-waste generated every year. [AS] [Str] This has the additional effect of increasing the rate of climate change. We will see that climate change comes up again later in this article. All of this has also sparked the movement *Right to Repair*, which pushes against planned obsolescence and calls for repairability of manufactured products. [Che]

Everything is a commodity

Advertising is used beyond just the selling of manufactured products, it is used to naturalise notions in support of capitalism and capitalist growth in our minds. Advertising has long been used to sway public opinion in the favour of capitalists, a good example of this is the climate change advertisements of western oil companies.

The conversation around Climate Change and Global Warming has since long turned into a conversation of personal responsiblity. We are taught to be mindful and frugal of our consumption of energy, we are to use electric cars and power-conserving LED lights, for whoever else will think of the planet? The carbon footprint of a person is a measure of the greenhouse gases released due to activities of the individual like the use of a car, disposing waste or using electricity[1]. The internet is filled with websites and apps that claim to track a person's carbon footprint; telling us to be mindful of our emissions. The reason for the conversation around climate change in regular spaces to have gone to personal responsiblity in the stead of responsiblity of oil companies and other corporations which have much larger control over the amount of greenhouse emissions produced in the world, is a result of massive ad campaigns by the likes of British Petroleum, ExxonMobil, Mobil and others. BP spent more than $100 million a year from 2004 to 2006 running marketing campaigns introducing the idea of a carbon footprint and bringing into focus lifestyle changes to reduce your carbon footprint. Before this in the 1990s, ExxonMobil ran print

[1] https://www.epa.gov/ghgemissions/carbon-footprint-calculator

ads questioning the science behind climate change and equated worry about global warming to alarmism. The awareness of the reality that climate change and global warming were real (Exxon's own studies showed this in 1979) did not hinder, but maybe even motivated, marketing campaigns denying climate change at first and then later on shifting the responsiblity onto individuals in true neoliberal fashion. [SO]

This denial of scientific findings, attempts to obscure them with fallacious studies conducted by the companies' research centers was the playbook of the tobacco industry much before oil companies used it for climate change. However this obscuring of scientific information is not exclusive to the cigarette and oil industries. Marico, the producer of the Parachute Coconut Hair Oil's research center has funded some of the most cited work on the effect of essential oils on hair health. [RM03]

The Che Guevara T-shirtification of Revolution

In the third season of Mad Men, the young copywriter, Smitty, hired to introduce coffee to a reluctant younger generation and otherwise to bring in a younger perspective into the copy writing of their advertising agency talks about a letter his friend wrote conveying revolutionary sentiments. Smitty suggests that they should use this desire to be free and rebel against repressive institutions in their marketing campaign to sell coffee. Once again, Mad Men points out a prominent trend in the advertising industry of co-opting, commodifying and, in some ways, neutering the different struggles for liberation. [Ric]

The Coca-Cola Company's famous "Buy the World a Coke" commercial where a collection of multicultural young people sing *"I'd Like to Teach the World to Sing"* and Pepsi's 2017 ad where Kylie Jenner emerging from a crowd of protestors opens a can of pepsi for a policeman are examples of how advertising under capitalism can commodify revolution itself. This is particularly characterised by the ubiquitous Che Guevara T-shirts mass produced in factories in the global south worked in by an exploited working class with little reprieve, the very people whose rights Che Guevara spent his life championing. The dissection and neutering of a revolutionary figure into a symbol of capitalist mass-production is emblematic of how advertisement in capitalist markets can sell you your own revolution [1].

What is one to think of the DEI programs and the brandishing of pride colors every June by corporations? Do these signify a turn of society towards a more equitable and freer version of itself? These changes do reflect a society more willing to accept certain marginalities as a natural part of society but they only do this insofar as it does not threaten capital. This is exemplified by the withdrawal of DEI efforts by American companies after Donald Trump assuming the Oval Office for his second term. It is also often seen that people who might come from marginalised sections of the society have amalgamated themself into the capitalist class, and become purveyors of the same oppression that was once inflicted on them [2].

Advertisement works to subvert the realization of human interests. Marcuse in his *One-Dimensional Man* distinguishes between 'true needs' and 'false needs.' False needs being those which are beset on someone by specific social interests in their repression. Marcuse argues that

[1] Phoebe Bridgers' *That Funny Feeling* talks about this and the dissociation that they feel from a society that is so well acquainted with voiding things of meaning. A line from the song— *"discount Etsy agitprop, Bugles' take on race"*

[2] https://www.business-humanrights.org/en/latest-news/sri-lanka-beyonces-ivy-park-line-allegedly-produced-in-sweatshop-includes-response/, https://www.ndtv.com/feature/kanye-west-selling-hakenkreuz-t-shirts-after-calling-himself-a-nazi-7685581

these false needs may bring great gratification to one but they have to be done away with. They serve in arresting one's development and impair one from recognising the "disease in the whole" and subsequent curing of this disease. The behaviours encouraged and set off by advertising, to relax, have fun and consume the way advertisements dictate. To love and hate what others love and hate, all fall squarely in this category of false needs. The realisation of these false needs does not lead to happiness but a repressive productivity which "promotes the satisfaction of needs which require continuing the rat race of catching up with one's peers and with planned obsolescence, enjoying freedom from using the brain, working with and for the means of destruction." [Mar64]

In conclusion, the surplus value that the capitalist class spends on advertisement is not only an affront to the labour of the working class but also actively undermines their autonomy and liberty. It works and relies on psychological operations, or psyops, to subvert culture and desire and mold them in service of capital. Going beyond just the selling of goods, it is actively used and acts to fight any real social and economic liberation and leads to alienation.

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